

The Call to Service

In the United States, the rights and obligations of citizenship have long engendered argument, and Vietnam was no different. Many Americans questioned the necessity of the war, and millions of young men chose to avoid military service.

◀◀ BEFORE

Americans viewed compulsory military service as a necessity during World War II and in the years that followed.

THE PEACETIME DRAFT

The Selective Training and Service Act of 1940 authorized the **first peacetime draft in US history**. After World War II, this was replaced by the Selective Service Act of 1948. As manpower needs in the 1950s and early 1960s were low, the system aroused **little opposition** among the public.

When President Johnson quietly escalated the war in the summer of 1965, he chose to rely on the draft to meet rising manpower needs rather than calling upon the National Guard and reserves. Johnson's reliance on conscription was intended to avoid a divisive public debate about the war, but instead it provoked one. When monthly draft calls more than doubled, young Americans who had never imagined joining the military were suddenly forced to contemplate combat in the remote jungles of South Vietnam. The draft cast a long shadow over America's youth.

Military service was not the experience of the majority of young men of the era. Of the 27 million men eligible to serve, only 11 million did so, and of these 2.5 million were deployed to Vietnam. Roughly one-third of those in Vietnam were volunteers motivated by patriotism, a hatred of communism, or the desire for a military career. Another third were draft-motivated volunteers who enlisted to have some control over their futures when conscription seemed imminent. The remaining third were draftees, often unable to invoke one of the lawful means of avoiding the draft, such as family hardship, infirmity, certain types of labor, conscientious objection, or student status.

Draft resisters

Of the 16 million who avoided military service during the period of US military involvement in Vietnam, only 600,000 actually broke the law by failing to report or fleeing abroad, most commonly to Canada. These draft resisters risked jail for refusing to fight a war they did not support.

By the late 1960s, a majority of Americans regarded the draft system as unfair. Local draft boards, usually composed of white men, often veterans themselves, adjudicated on requests for deferments while trying to meet their quotas. Men of means who could provide documentation of physical infirmity from doctors or long-standing moral pacifism from clergymen had an advantage in this process. Poor men and men of color were least likely to avoid military service, because draft boards tended to defer white, middle-class men whose futures were deemed more valuable than those unable to afford college. The unfairness of this led to incremental changes to the system that eventually ended graduate school and teaching deferments.

“Hell no, we won’t go!”

POPULAR ANTIWAR, ANTI-DRAFT SLOGAN OF THE 1960S AND 1970S